

Global Container Port Throughput by Economy

A comparative analysis of reported container port activity, 2020–2024

5	136	101
years analyzed	economies with annual rows	economies with complete reported series

Project objective

Compare economies using UNCTAD-reported annual container port throughput in TEUs. The analysis examines 2024 leaders, rank movement, 2020–2024 changes, the complete-series trend, and year-to-year variability.

Python analysis in Google Colab · UNCTADstat dataset

Project Overview

Objective and scope

The dataset reports country- and territory-level reporting units (“economies”). Throughput represents container handling associated with loading, unloading, repositioning, and transshipment. One 20-foot container equals 1 TEU; one 40-foot container equals 2 TEUs. The measure describes port activity, not cargo weight, trade value, company revenue, or port capacity. Some smaller ports may not be included.

Business questions

- Q1 — Which economies had the highest reported container throughput in 2024?
- Q2 — How did the 2024 leaders’ rankings change from 2020 to 2024?
- Q3 — Which comparable economies had the largest absolute and percentage changes from 2020 to 2024?
- Q4 — How did combined throughput change each year among economies with values for all five years?
- Q5 — Among economies with values in every year, which had the most consistent and most variable year-to-year percentage changes?

Data source and measure

UNCTADstat, Container port throughput, annual (analytical), CSV data for 2020–2024. Values are annual TEU estimates by economy.

[UNCTADstat dataset page](#)

Data quality checks

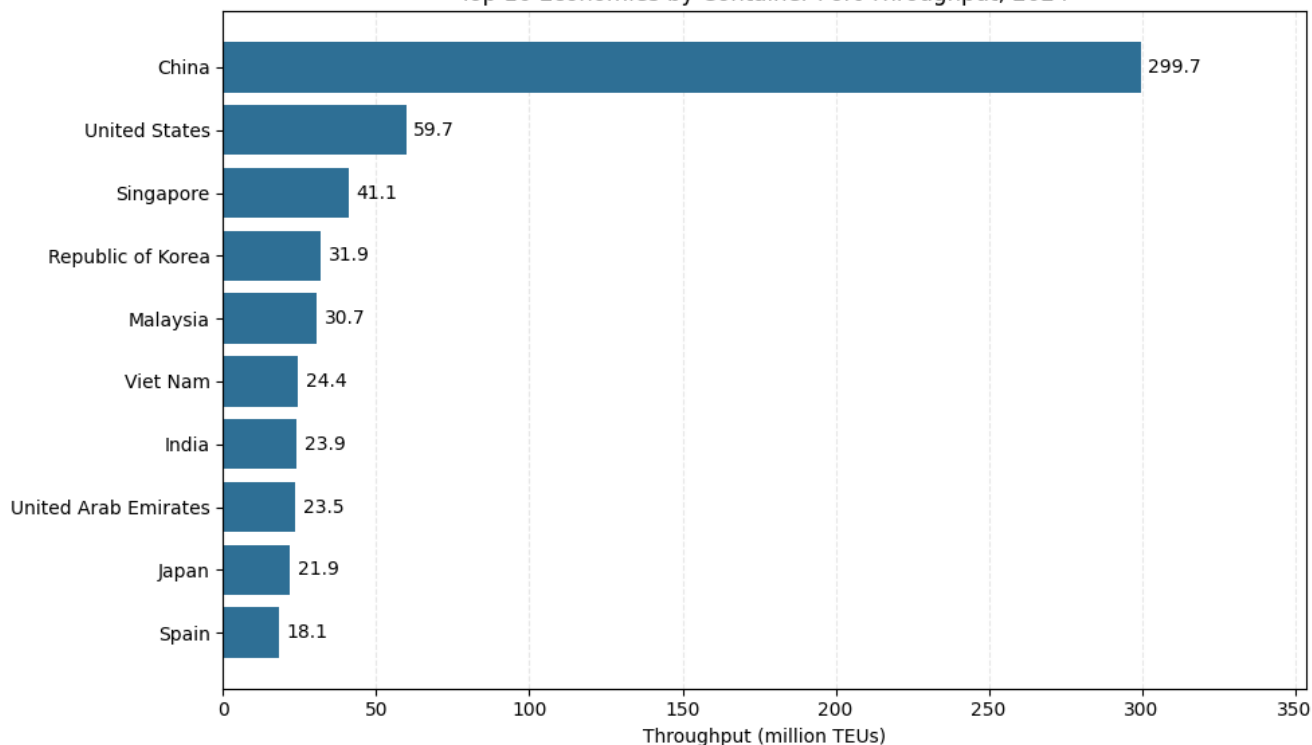
The CSV includes 136 economies with rows for each year (680 economy-year records) and five summary-placeholder rows. There were no duplicate rows or duplicate economy-year records. Of the 680 economy-year throughput values, 88 were unavailable: 78 labeled “Not publishable” and 10 “Not applicable.” Missing values were not treated as zero. The analysis used 592 reported numeric values from 130 economies; reported values passed numeric, finite, and nonnegative checks. A complete five-year series was available for 101 economies.

Comparison groups: Q3 compares the 105 economies with reported values in both 2020 and 2024. Q4 and Q5 use the 101 economies with reported values in all five years. Ranks are calculated among economies with reported values in each year.

Q1 — Which Economies Had the Highest Reported Throughput in 2024?

China ranked first with 299.7 million TEUs—about five times the United States, which ranked second with 59.7 million. Singapore ranked third with 41.1 million TEUs.

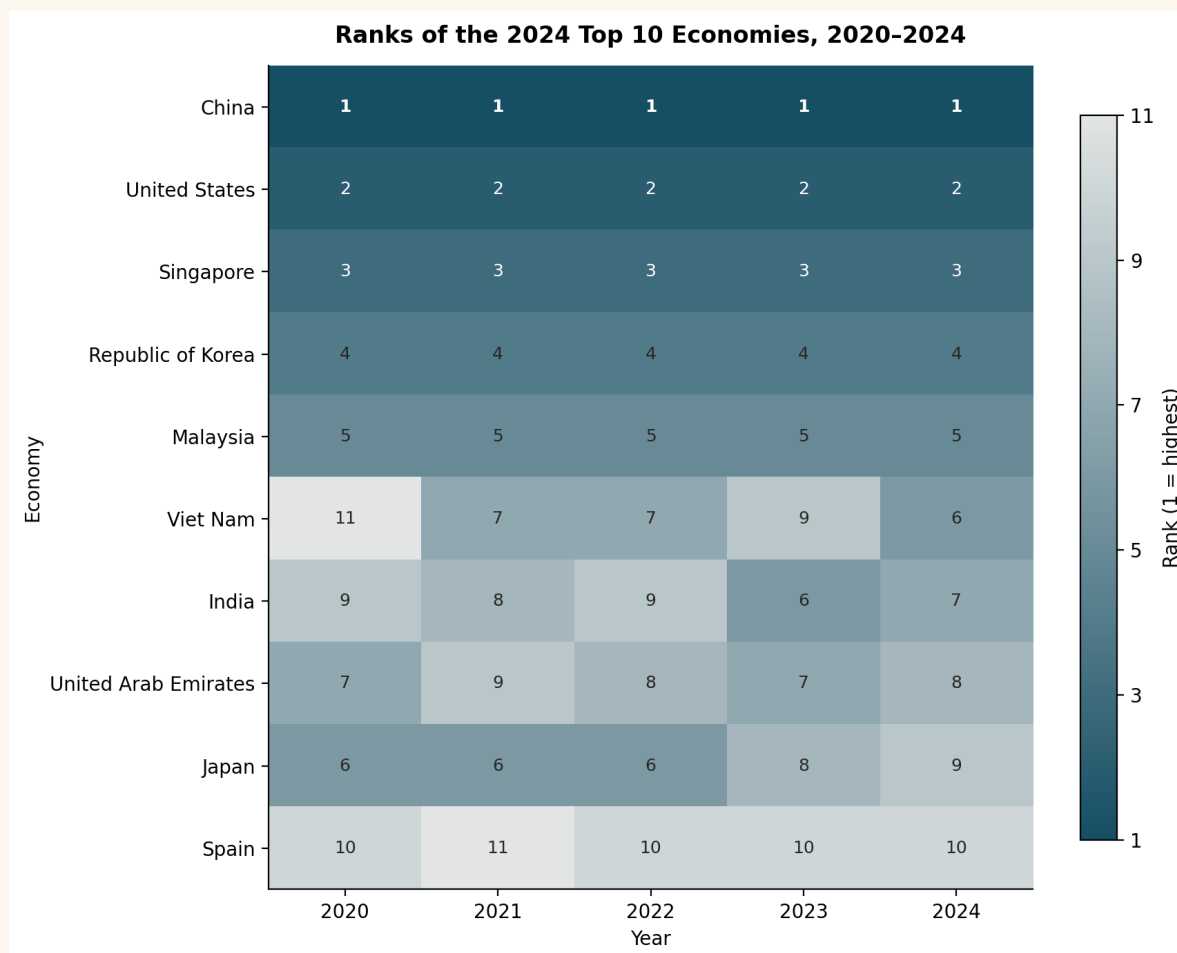
Top 10 Economies by Container Port Throughput, 2024



The horizontal bars compare the ten economies with the highest reported throughput in 2024. Values are shown in millions of TEUs.

Q2 — How Did the 2024 Leaders' Rankings Change?

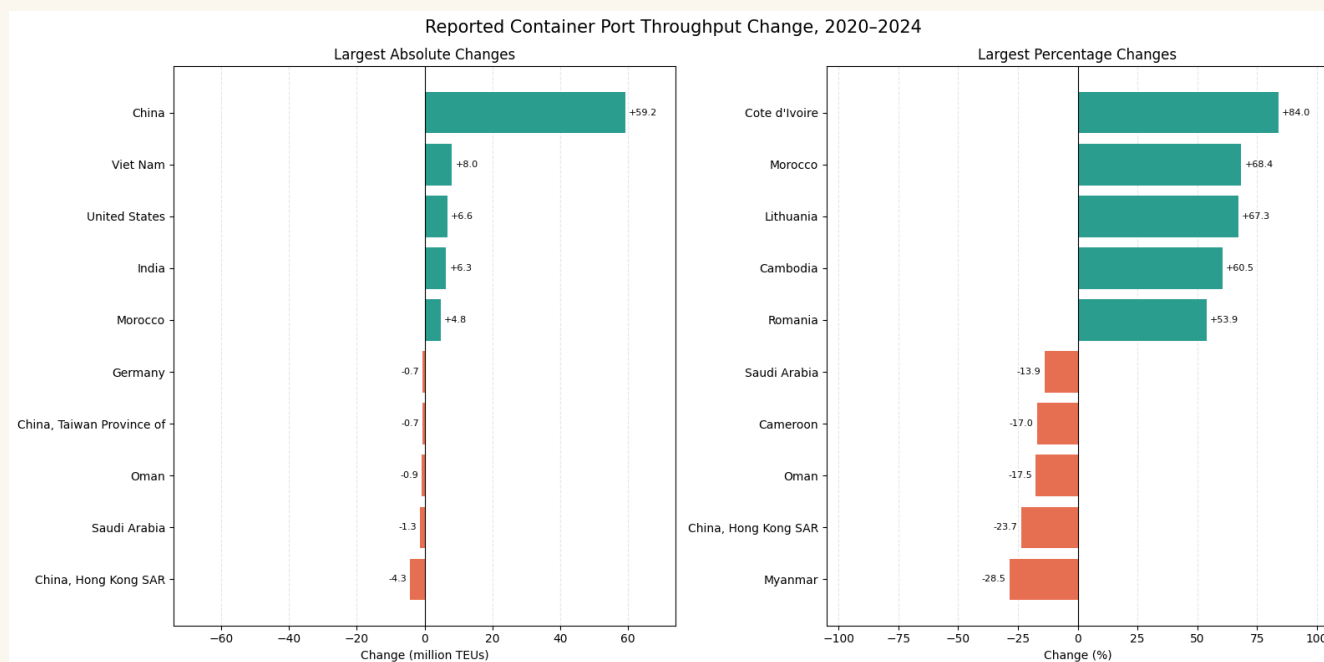
The top five economies kept the same ranks throughout the period. Viet Nam rose from 11th in 2020 to 6th in 2024. Japan moved from 6th to 9th, while India rose from 9th to 7th.



Rank 1 is highest. The heatmap uses a single-hue sequential scale to show rank order without suggesting that a rank is “good” or “bad.” Each year’s ranks include economies with reported values for that year.

Q3 — Which Economies Had the Largest Changes, 2020-2024?

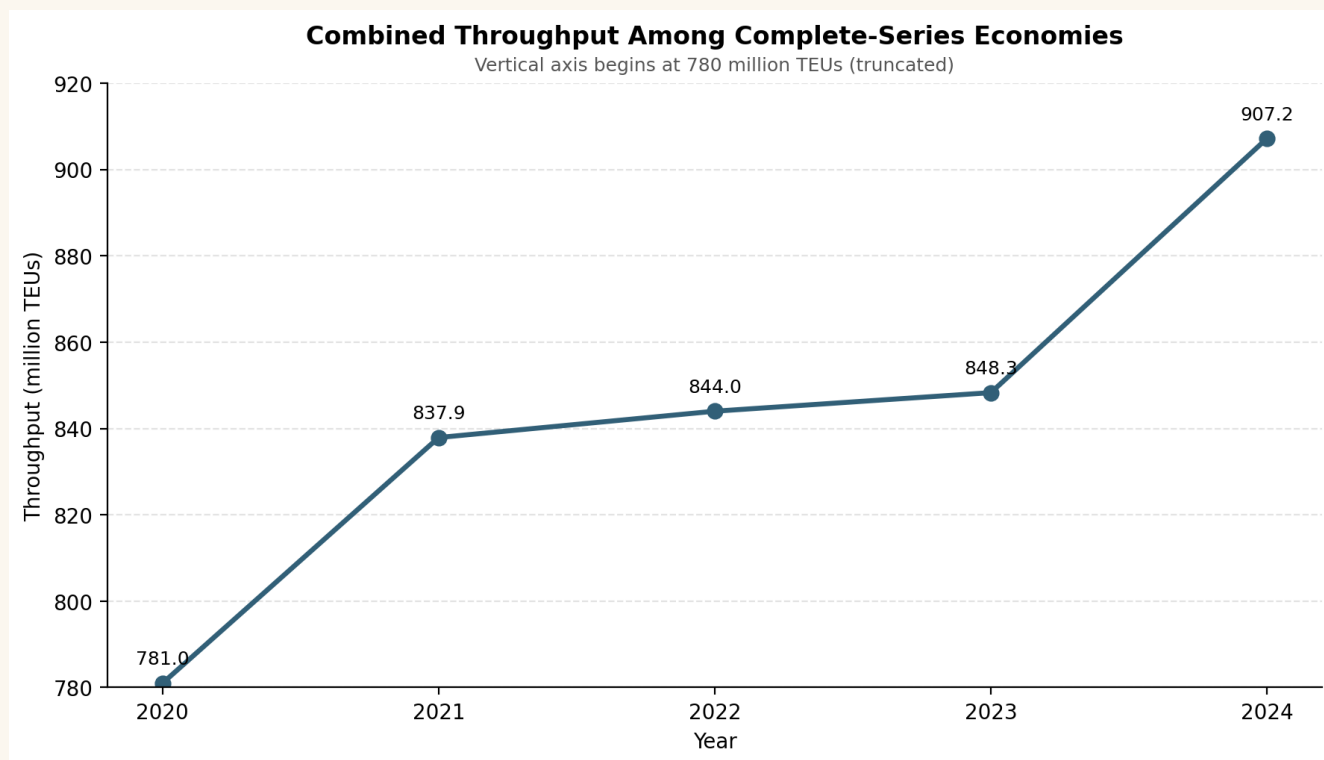
Among 105 economies with values in both years, China had the largest absolute increase (+59.2 million TEUs). Côte d'Ivoire had the largest percentage increase (+84.0%), while Morocco ranked highly on both measures (+4.8 million TEUs; +68.4%). China, Hong Kong SAR had the largest absolute decline (−4.3 million TEUs); Myanmar had the largest percentage decline (−28.5%, about 312,000 TEUs).



The left panel shows absolute change in millions of TEUs; the right shows percentage change relative to 2020 throughput. Bars right of zero are increases; bars left are decreases. Each panel shows the five largest increases and decreases.

Q4 — How Did Combined Throughput Change Each Year?

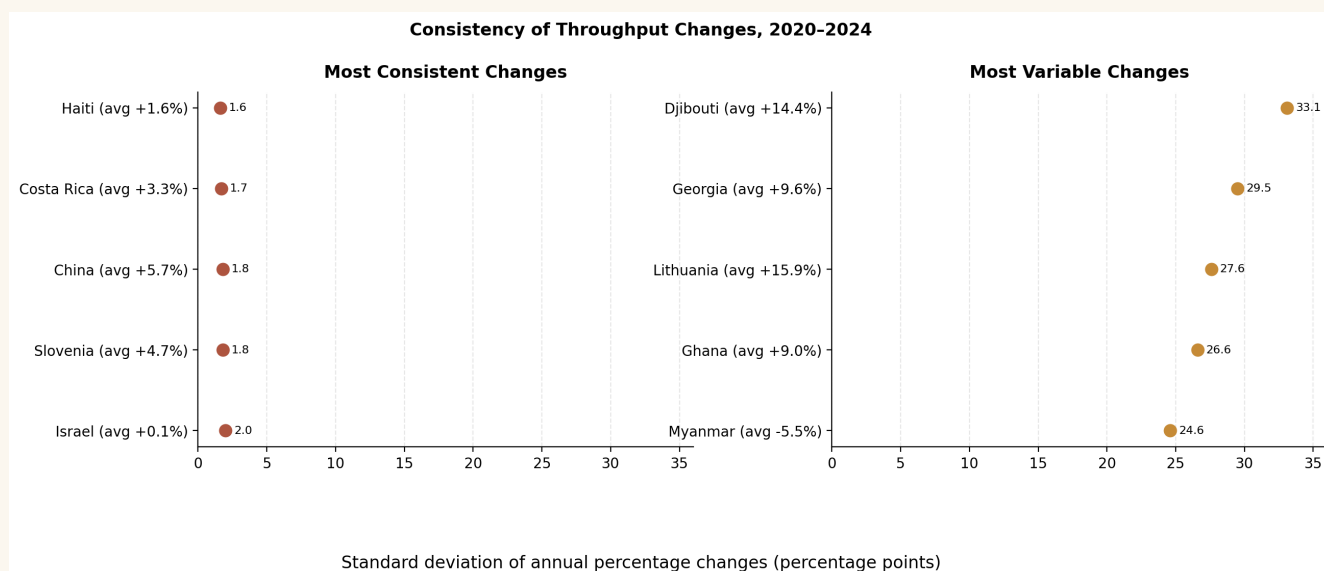
For the 101 complete-series economies, combined reported throughput rose from 781.0 million TEUs in 2020 to 907.2 million in 2024—an increase of 126.2 million TEUs (about 16.2%). Growth was sharp from 2020 to 2021, more gradual through 2023, and sharp again in 2024.



This is not a global total. The chart labels its truncated vertical scale directly: the y-axis begins at 780 million TEUs. Use the data labels to compare point values.

Q5 — Which Economies' Changes Were Most Consistent or Variable?

Among the 101 economies compared, Haiti had the most consistent annual percentage changes (standard deviation: 1.6 percentage points; average annual change: +1.6%). Djibouti had the most variable changes (standard deviation: 33.1 percentage points; average annual change: +14.4%). The average does not mean Djibouti's throughput rose by 14.4% in every year.



Each dot represents an economy. Lower standard deviation means steadier year-to-year percentage changes; higher standard deviation means greater variation. The plot shows the five most consistent and five most variable economies.

Overall Conclusion and Recommendations

Overall conclusion

China led reported throughput in 2024 and remained first throughout 2020–2024; the top five economies kept their ranks. In the endpoint comparison, China had the largest absolute increase, while Côte d'Ivoire had the largest percentage increase. China, Hong Kong SAR had the largest absolute decline, and Myanmar the largest percentage decline. For the 101 complete-series economies, combined reported throughput rose about 16.2%. Haiti had the most consistent annual percentage changes and Djibouti the most variable.

Recommendations

- Use throughput changes as signals for further review. China had the largest absolute increase; compare it with port-level capacity and utilization before considering capacity changes.
- Interpret percentage growth alongside absolute volume. Côte d'Ivoire had the largest percentage increase, while Morocco ranked highly on both measures. Check starting volumes and port-level trends.
- Monitor large year-to-year fluctuations. Djibouti had the most variable annual percentage changes. Compare this pattern with port operations and trade data to investigate possible drivers.
- Add industry context in follow-up analysis. Cross-reference throughput changes with regional trade agreement developments and liner capacity deployments. These external factors were not tested here, so the comparison can guide investigation but cannot establish causes.

Country-level throughput is a useful screening measure, but investment decisions require port-level operational and capacity evidence.

Limitations and Source

- The data is reported at the economy level and does not distinguish individual ports or shipping companies.
- Some economy-year values are unavailable; the combined five-year trend covers only 101 economies with complete reported values.
- The analysis covers 2020–2024 and describes observed changes; it does not establish causes or predict future throughput.
- UNCTAD notes that some smaller ports may not be included in reported country-level estimates.

Data source

UNCTADstat. Container port throughput, annual (analytical). CSV data for 2020–2024.

[Open the UNCTADstat dataset page](#)

All findings refer to reported container port throughput in TEUs and should be interpreted within the data scope and comparison rules described in this report.